from every community, gender, caste and religion. They all want an MP who will make a difference. Your religion doesn't matter.

MODI'S TRACK RECORD

Tharoor: The Modi government has presided over the worst unemployment figures the country has ever seen, with the educated young being the biggest victims. In Kerala, over 45 per cent in the 20-24 age group are unemployed. If the aspirational young have nothing to look forward to, it is a recipe for disaster.

Chandrasekhar: How Modi has transformed India in 10 years of governance can easily be compared with eight years of Left rule in Kerala and the earlier 10 years of the Congress at the Centre. The BJP is being seen by people as the party that would help build a better future for them and their children, for development and prosperity.

IMPACT OF THE RAM TEMPLE

Tharoor: The Congress's reason for not attending the temple inauguration was—why should we attend a political event where the chief priest appears to be the PM? I have said to people, 'I'm not going to surrender my Ram to the BJP'. I don't think the BJP has a copyright on Lord Ram. I will go on a non-political occasion as a worshipper.

Chandrasekhar: It is not my focus. My campaign is based on people's aspirations—investments, jobs, skilling, progress that cuts across communities. It is about the Modi government's Sabka Saath Sabka Vikas policy, which ensures progress.

THE ASSET CONTROVERSY

Tharoor: I would prefer to actually beat him fair and square rather than have him disqualified because of mistakes in his affidavit over his assets declaration. But it's the democratic right of a party to challenge a false affidavit.

Chandrasekhar: It is the same disclosure I've been making for 18 years. It is absolutely accurate and represents what my assets are. ■

pro-Palestine rally organised by the Indian Union Muslim League in October. That's two natural support groups in a sullen mood. Worse for him, Chandrasekhar is likely to seriously dent his Hindu vote.

The other issue that can polarise votes is the controversy over Doordarshan airing the film *The Kerala Story* (2022), which depicts four women from the state converting to Islam and joining the Islamic State. The CPI(M) and Congress have protested the timing of the screening, with Tharoor terming it "propaganda at its cheapest and worst". The BJP has defended it, accusing those against the screening of "encouraging extremism". Now, the decision of two Catholic Syro-Malabar dioceses to screen the movie at church events to "enlighten teenagers against love jehad", has further stirred the pot. (A counter from other churches made the debate more fascinating.)

THE BALANCE CAN TILT IN THAROOR'S FAVOUR IF THE CPI(M) DECIDES TO TRANSFER ITS VOTES TO HIM, LIKE IT DID IN 2014, TO DENY THE BJP A VICTORY

Meanwhile, Chandrasekhar is in a spot of bother, with the Congress submitting a complaint to the Election Commission (EC) on April 8, accusing him of concealing his assets and giving false information about his financial status in his election affidavit. This includes declaring his taxable income as Rs 680 for the post-Covid financial year 2021-22. Chandrasekhar has denied the charges, saying, "It is absolutely accurate and represents what my assets are." The EC has directed the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) to verify the affidavit.

So, what's the last coin that can tilt the scales? With April 26 just two weeks away, the final mile on the campaign marathon will be decisive. Tharoor has gone all guns blazing against the BJP's Hindutva pitch, charging it with destroying the country's social harmony, saying, "The way it has targeted the Muslims is nothing short of a betrayal of the sacred compact of Indian independence, the very cause for which Mahatma Gandhi gave his life. He died with 'Hey Ram' on his lips and the BJP talks of Ram Rajya. It is fair to ask, is the BJP talking about Gandhiji's Ram Rajya or about Godse's Ram Rajya?"

Chandrasekhar carefully avoids joining issue with Tharoor on the communal card, dismissing it "as the old strategy of fear-mongering and peddling lies to scare minorities". Instead, he says, "My campaign is based on people's aspirations—investments, jobs, skilling, progress that cuts across communities." What could tilt the balance in Tharoor's favour is if the CPI(M), which is part of the I.N.D.I.A. alliance, decides to transfer its votes to Tharoor, as it did in 2014 to stave off a possible saffron victory. However, this time, after topping a 30 per cent vote share twice in succession, the BJP scents blood. So, it may come down to whether the CPI(M) feels a strong urge going beyond fraternal loyalty to deny Team Modi a chance to register its debut victory in the Kerala capital. ■